

Start Here, Mark

Your business in a folder. Read this one all the way through.

Prepared for Mark Strazisar

This is your business in a folder. Read this one file all the way through. It is written for you, in plain words, with no rush. When you finish it, you will know exactly what the business is, why you are the right person for it, and what to do first.

Take it one page at a time. Nothing here needs to happen today.

What this is, in one page

Here is the business in one sentence.

You help busy restaurant groups turn what lives in their best people's heads into clear written playbooks, so every location runs the same way and every new opening starts from a proven plan instead of a blank page.

That is it. You are not cooking. You are not running a floor at night. You are not on a clock. You are writing down how good operations actually work, for the people who need it written down and do not have time to do it themselves.

Here is what your day looks like.

You sit down at home with a cup of coffee. You pick one document to work on, say a server training manual. You open Claude on your computer and you talk to it for about ten minutes, the same way you would explain the job to a sharp new manager. Claude writes up a clean first draft while you talk. You read it, fix anything that is not quite how you do it, and save it. You are done for the day if you want to be. The next day you pick the next document.

That is the whole rhythm. Talk, review, save. You already know everything you need to know. The tool just helps you get it onto the page fast.

You do this from your couch, your kitchen table, or your bed on a rough day. There is no commute, no shift, no boss standing over you. You decide when you work and how much.

Why this works, and why it is you specifically

Most people who try to sell this have a problem. They have never run a restaurant. They are guessing.

You are not guessing. You have done it for 25 years.

Look at your own record. You have personally built and operated around 15 concepts. Restaurants, bars, lounges, nightclubs, a coffee shop, and a family fun center. You were the owner. You were the Chief Operating Officer. You were the Vice President of Operations. You wrote the training manuals. You wrote the safety procedures. You built the hiring and onboarding

programs. You ran the profit and loss statements. You mentored the general managers who ran your floors.

You took Beta Nightclub to the number one ranking in North America. You doubled sales at SUTRA Lounge. You are known for finding the real reason something keeps going wrong and fixing the system so it stops.

Read that again. **You have already built the exact thing you are now going to sell.** Training manuals. Safety procedures. Onboarding. Operating systems. You did it under real pressure, with your own money on the line, and it worked.

So this is not a new career. It is the same work you have always been great at, packaged in a way that lets you do it from home, at your own pace, and get paid well for it.

The only new part is the tool. You have never used artificial intelligence. That is fine. By the end of this folder you will have used it, and you will see it is just a very fast, very patient assistant that types while you talk. You stay in charge of every word.

The offer, described simply

You sell finished documents that make a restaurant group run better and grow easier.

There are three families of documents.

1. **Operations core.** The day to day backbone. Opening and closing procedures, cash handling, cleaning schedules, inventory and ordering, food safety, emergency procedures, manager shift checklists.
2. **Employee and training.** How people learn the job. Onboarding programs, server and bartender and host training manuals, steps of service, menu knowledge guides, coaching frameworks.
3. **Standards and scaling.** How the group stays consistent and opens new spots. Brand and service standards, audit checklists, and the big one, the new location opening playbook.

You can sell one document at a time, a package, or a full system. You can sell it once, or you can sell an ongoing arrangement where you keep everything current as the group grows. The full menu and the pricing are a few pages down.

The single most valuable thing you offer is the **new location opening playbook**. A growing group opens new spots all the time, and most of them rebuild the plan from scratch every time. You give them one proven playbook they can run every time. That saves them weeks of work and a lot of opening night chaos. We will highlight it again later because it is your flagship.

Goals for the first 30, 60, and 90 days

These goals are gentle on purpose. You measure progress in documents finished, not hours worked. A finished document is a win. Three finished documents is a real portfolio. That is how we keep score.

First 30 days. Get set up and prove it to yourself.

- Set up Claude on your computer.
- Make one finished sample document, start to finish, on your own.
- Make two or three more so you have a small portfolio.
- Shape your simple pitch.
- Have the first friendly conversation with your group.

That is the whole first month. Notice there is no revenue goal. The first month is about proving to yourself that you can do this, because you can, and getting one real document in your hand to show people.

Days 31 to 60. Turn it into an arrangement.

- Land your first paying arrangement, ideally the monthly retainer with your group.
- Deliver the first two or three documents they actually need.
- Settle into a comfortable weekly rhythm.

Days 61 to 90. Build the engine.

- Be steadily producing documents under a retainer or project.
- Start the new location opening playbook, your most valuable piece.
- Have a simple library of finished work you can reuse and resell later.

If it takes you longer than this, that is completely fine. These are mile markers, not deadlines. The retainer model, which we will get to, is built so that a slow week never costs you the work.

The at home playbook, step by step

This section is the how to. Follow it in order the first time. After that you will not need it.

Step 1. Set up Claude

Claude is the assistant you will talk to. It types up your knowledge while you explain it.

1. Go to claude.ai and create an account with your email.
2. Subscribe to the plan called **Claude Pro**. It costs about 20 dollars a month. That is your only required cost to run this entire business. No office, no software suite, nothing else.

3. Pro includes the **desktop app**, sometimes called Cowork. Download it to your computer. The desktop app is the one you want, because it lets you talk through a task and watch Claude write it up, and it can work right alongside your files.
4. Open the app and sign in. You will see a simple box where you type or talk. That is all there is to it.

That is your whole setup. Twenty dollars a month and an afternoon.

Step 2. Organize your folders

Keep it simple. On your computer, make one main folder called **My Documents Business**. Inside it, make these folders.

- **Clients.** One folder per group you work with. Start with one called Culinary Creative.
- **Finished.** Every completed document goes here.
- **Templates.** Your reusable versions, with the client's name taken out, so you can sell the same document to the next group later.
- **Samples.** Your proof pieces you show before anyone hires you.

When you finish a document, save it in Finished, then save a clean copy in Templates with the names removed. That second copy is money in the bank for later. We will explain why in the section on where this can grow.

Step 3. Make one document, start to finish

This is the heart of the whole business. Once you can do this, you can do everything. Here is the exact walkthrough. We will use a server training manual as the example.

Talk for about ten minutes. Open the Claude desktop app. Tell it what you want in plain words. You can type it or say it out loud. Something like this.

I spent 25 years running restaurants and bars. I am writing a server training manual for a casual neighborhood burger and beer spot. I am going to talk you through how a server really learns this job, start to shift. Take notes and ask me questions if I skip something. Then write it up as a clean training manual a brand new server could follow.

Then just talk, the way you would walk a new manager through it. How does a server's shift start. What do they set up. What are the steps of service from greeting to goodbye. How do they handle a complaint. How do they close out. Do not worry about order or grammar. Just get it out of your head. If you forget something, Claude will ask. That is what it is there for.

Let Claude write it up. When you are done talking, say "okay, write the full manual now." Claude will turn your ten minutes of talking into a clean, organized document with headings, steps, and sections. This takes seconds.

Read it and fix anything wrong. This is your most important job, and only you can do it. Read the draft. Where it got something wrong, or made it too fancy, or missed how you actually do it, tell Claude. Say "the closing section is wrong, here is how we really close" and talk again. It fixes it instantly. Repeat until it sounds like you. Usually two or three rounds.

Save it. When it is right, copy the document into your Finished folder. Give it a clear name like "Server Training Manual, Tap and Burger." Save a clean copy in Templates with the client name removed. Done.

That is one finished, sellable document. Start to finish, maybe an hour the first time, faster after that. You did the thinking. The tool did the typing.

There are ready made prompts for every document type in the Copy and Paste Prompts document, inside the Tools and Examples folder. You can paste one in, fill in a couple of blanks, and start talking. That document is your shortcut so you never face a blank screen.

What you sell, the full menu

Here is everything you can offer, grouped into the three families, and then packaged so it is easy to sell.

Operations core

- Opening and closing procedures, front of house and back of house
- Cash handling and end of night reconciliation
- Daily, weekly, and monthly cleaning and sanitation schedules
- Inventory, ordering, and par level procedures
- Receiving and vendor standards
- Food safety and health code procedures
- Emergency and incident procedures, including medical, fire, security, and refusing service
- Manager daily checklist and shift handover

Employee and training

- New hire onboarding program
- Server training manual
- Bartender training manual
- Host and door training
- Busser and food runner training
- Kitchen line and prep training
- Steps of service guide

- Menu and bar knowledge guides
- Coaching and performance conversation framework

Standards and scaling

- Brand and service standards guide, the definition of what consistent looks like across every location
- Audit and self inspection checklists
- Recipe and plating spec templates
- Train the trainer guide
- Knowledge base structure, so all of the above lives in one organized library

The flagship, highlighted

The new location opening playbook. This is your most valuable product. It is the complete, repeatable plan for opening a new spot. A countdown timeline from lease to opening day, the build and equipment checklist, the hiring and training calendar, the pre opening punch lists, the soft opening plan, and the first week operating plan. A group that opens locations regularly will value this more than anything else, because it turns every opening from a scramble into a routine. Lead with this when you pitch a growing group.

Packaged so it is easy to buy

- **Single document.** Any one of the above, on its own.
 - **Concept Starter Pack.** The operations core plus the main training manuals for one concept. Gets one location fully documented.
 - **Full Concept System.** Everything above for one concept, soup to nuts.
 - **New Location Opening Playbook.** The flagship, sold on its own or as the centerpiece of a retainer.
 - **Group Standards System.** The brand standards, audits, and shared library that tie all locations together. This is the big one for a multi location group.
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Pricing, grounded in real numbers

Every number here sits inside what real restaurant and operations consultants charge in 2026. The Research Notes document, marked 6, shows the sources. There are three ways to charge. The retainer is the one I recommend, and I will explain why.

The anchor, so you know your value

If this group hired an outside consulting firm to build their whole operations and opening system from the outside, it would realistically cost them **30,000 to 75,000 dollars or more**, plus travel, plus weeks of that firm learning their concepts from scratch. You already know their floors. Your discovery time is close to zero. That is your edge, and it is why your prices are fair and still a bargain for them.

Way 1. Per document

Charge for each finished document. Good for testing the water or for one off needs.

- Simple documents, like a checklist or a one page procedure: **150 to 300 dollars** each.
- Standard documents, like a full role training manual or a multi step procedure: **400 to 750 dollars** each.
- The new location opening playbook, sold as its own package: **3,500 to 6,000 dollars**.

Way 2. Monthly retainer, recommended

You agree to build a set amount of work each month for a flat monthly fee. This is the best model for you, and here is why. It gives you steady, predictable income. It does not punish you on a slow week or a hard health day, because they are paying for the finished work over the month, not for your hours. And it matches how a growing group actually needs you, a little at a time, ongoing.

- **Build period: 3,000 dollars per month.** This is while you are building the core system, usually three to six months. Most groups land somewhere between 9,000 and 18,000 dollars total for the full core build, depending on pace.
- **Maintenance: 1,000 dollars per month** after the build. This keeps everything current as they open new spots, change menus, and adjust procedures. It is light work for you and steady money, and it keeps you as their person.

Way 3. Project fee

One fixed price for a defined, complete system, paid in milestones as you finish each part.

- **Full core operations and training system for one concept: 18,000 to 25,000 dollars.**
- Paid in thirds. One third to start, one third at the halfway mark, one third on delivery.

Use the project fee when a client wants a fixed, complete scope delivered by a certain date. Use per document to start small. Steer toward the retainer whenever you can, because steady beats lumpy, especially for you.

How to pitch The Culinary Creative Group

This is the part that probably feels hardest, so we made it the easiest. You are not cold selling. You already work there. You are offering to solve a problem you can see better than almost anyone.

First, the most important rule. **Stay in your lane and say so out loud.** The group already has a Director of Human Resources and a recruiting manager. You are not touching hiring law, benefits, payroll, or compliance. Your lane is floor level operations. How the work gets done, how people are trained to do it, and how a new location opens cleanly. When you make that clear, you are not a threat to anyone. You are a missing piece that makes the HR team's job easier, because well trained people on documented systems are easier to manage.

Second, an angle that is working in your favor right now. The group's new Chief Executive, Richard Flaherty, came from Punch Bowl Social and Wagamama. Those are brands built on repeatable systems and openings that run the same way every time. A leader from that world already believes in written playbooks. You will not have to convince him that systems matter. You only have to show him you can build them for these concepts, from the inside, fast. One quick note. Leadership there changed recently, so before you walk in, confirm the current names and titles of whoever you are talking to. It is a small thing that keeps you looking sharp.

Third, name the payoff in their words. A systems minded leader buys results, not paper. So say what the work is worth. A documented opening playbook can save weeks of work on every new location and keep the guest experience the same across all of them. That is real money and real reputation. Put it in plain numbers if you can, like the days saved on the next opening.

Here is your script. It is short and humble. Pick the version that fits where you are.

Version A, if you are still on salary there

Use this with whoever you report to, in a calm one on one.

Can I run an idea by you. We keep opening new spots, and every time, a lot of the training and the procedures get rebuilt from scratch, because so much of how we run is in people's heads. I have spent my whole career building exactly that kind of thing, training manuals, opening playbooks, the operating systems. I would like to start writing ours down, location by location, so every spot runs the same and every opening starts from a proven plan. I can do this on the side, on my own time, without stepping on HR or recruiting at all. This is pure floor operations. Could we try one document, my treat, and you tell me if it is useful.

That last line is the key. You offer one free sample. Almost no one says no to free and useful.

Version B, if you are fully off work right now

Use this as a friendly outreach to your former manager or the operations leader.

I have been building something I think the group could really use. As we keep opening locations, the training and the opening procedures get rebuilt every time, and a lot of it lives in people's heads. I have put together a way to capture all of that into clean playbooks, location by location, so openings get easier and every spot runs consistent. It stays completely in the operations lane, no overlap with HR or recruiting. I would love to show you one finished example I built for a concept like ours and talk about whether it would help. No pressure at all.

In both versions you lead with the problem they already feel, you point to your track record, you make the HR boundary clear, and you ask for one small yes. That is the whole pitch.

If you are still on salary, set it up the right way

This is the one part to handle carefully, so it never becomes awkward. If you pitch your own employer while you are still on their payroll, the fair question they may think is, "is this not just part of his job already." Get ahead of it, calmly and in the open.

- **Get a yes in writing before you do any paid work.** A short, friendly email is enough. Confirm that you will build these documents as a separate paid arrangement, outside your regular duties, and that they are happy with that. This protects both of you.
- **Be clear about what belongs to whom.** Work you do as part of your salaried job usually belongs to the company. This paid arrangement is for work beyond your role. Your reusable templates, with the names and private details removed, stay yours. Say that plainly and put it in writing too. There is a simple plain language scope note for this, the Simple Agreement and Scope document in the Tools and Examples folder, that you can use for all of it.
- **If they say "just do this as part of your job," you still win.** You have two good moves. One, agree on a defined extra project with its own scope and a stipend or bonus, so the extra work is recognized and paid. Two, keep it warm and revisit a paid arrangement when you move off salary, while you keep building your own library in the meantime. Either way, you proved the value, and that is the real goal.

How to talk about how you work

You will wonder whether to mention the tool. Here is the simple truth that keeps you honest and keeps your value clear.

- **You are selling 25 years of knowing what actually works on a floor.** That is the product. The tool is just how you type it up fast.
- **It is fine to be open about using modern tools.** If it comes up, the honest line is easy: "I use good tools to get it on the page quickly, but you are paying for what only I know, what really works on a floor and what does not."
- **Never lead with the tool, and never lead with what it costs you.** A group is not paying a monthly fee for typing. They are paying for judgment they cannot get anywhere else. Lead with

the problem you solve and the years behind you. The tool is a detail.

Doing this while you are not at full strength

Let me say this plainly, because it matters. You are dealing with a serious illness, and this business is built around that, not in spite of it.

This is the only kind of work that fits. No floor. No clock. No shift you have to show up for. You work from home, in short bursts, when you have the energy. Twenty good minutes is enough to move a document forward. On a hard day, you rest, and nothing breaks.

A few permissions, in writing, so you can come back to them.

- **You are allowed to work in short bursts.** A document does not need to be finished in one sitting. Talk for ten minutes today, review tomorrow, save the day after. It still counts.
- **Stack the easy days.** On a good day, get ahead. Bank a couple of finished documents. That buffer covers the hard days.
- **Rest the hard days with no guilt.** The work waits. It does not expire.
- **This is exactly why the retainer matters.** When a client pays you a flat monthly fee for the finished work, a slow week does not cost you a dime. You are not selling hours, so a hard day is not a lost day of pay. That structure is your protection. Lead with it.

You built businesses that ran while you slept. This one runs around your health.

Your first proof piece

Do not pitch with an idea. Pitch with a finished example in your hand. It changes everything. An idea is easy to say no to. A real, polished document they can hold and flip through is almost impossible to dismiss.

So before you talk to anyone, build **one finished sample document**, tied to a real concept you can point to. A great choice is a server training manual or an opening checklist for a casual neighborhood burger and beer spot, because the group has exactly that kind of concept and it is easy for anyone to picture.

Good news. Two finished, polished samples are already here for you, in the Tools and Examples folder, each marked as a Sample. A complete server training manual and a complete front and back of house opening checklist, both written for a Tap and Burger style concept. Read them. Make them yours. Use them as your proof pieces on day one, or rebuild them in your own voice as your very first practice documents. Either way, you walk into your first conversation with something real.

A simple progress tracker

Keep score by documents finished. Copy this into a note on your phone or a sheet on your computer, and check a box each time. That is the whole system.

```
WEEK 1
[ ] Claude Pro set up on my computer
[ ] Folders created
[ ] First sample document finished, start to finish

WEEK 2
[ ] Second document finished
[ ] Third document finished
[ ] Pitch script picked and practiced once out loud

WEEK 3
[ ] First conversation with the group had
[ ] One free sample offered

WEEK 4
[ ] Arrangement discussed or agreed
[ ] New location opening playbook started

ONGOING
Documents finished this month: ____
Best day this week: ____
Rest days taken with no guilt: ____
```

Finished documents are the only number that matters. Hours do not count. Rest does not subtract. A finished document is always a win.

Where this can grow

Start with one group. But look at what you are building underneath.

Every document you finish, you save twice. Once for the client, and once as a clean template with the names removed. After a few months you will have a library of proven, reusable playbooks. That library is an asset, and it grows in value the more you build.

Here is where it can go.

- **Sell the same templates to other groups.** The next burger concept, the next group of bars, the next coffee operation. You already built the playbook. The second sale is mostly editing names and details. Far less work, same price.

- **Productize the opening playbook.** A repeatable new location opening playbook is something almost every growing operator wants and almost none have. That alone can become a steady product.
- **Feed the group's own consulting arm.** The Culinary Creative Group runs a consulting practice. The clean systems you build for their restaurants could become tools their consulting clients pay for too. That is a bigger conversation for later, but the door is open, and you would be the natural person to walk through it.

One caution, so this stays clean. The documents you build specifically for a client belong to that client. What you keep and reuse are your own templates and methods, with their private details removed. Keep that line clear and agree on it in writing, using the Simple Agreement and Scope document in the Tools and Examples folder. Be thoughtful about reselling anything that is truly specific to one group, especially this one, since they run their own consulting practice. Your knowledge and your general templates travel with you. Their private details and recipes do not. Hold that line and your reputation stays spotless.

You are not just doing work. You are building a catalog. Each finished document is a brick. The library is the house.

A friendly FAQ

I have never used artificial intelligence. Is this really for me?

Yes. If you can explain a job to a new manager out loud, you can do this. The tool just types while you talk. You will be comfortable with it within one afternoon. The walkthrough in the at home playbook is written so you can do it the first time with no help.

Will the documents sound like a computer wrote them?

Only if you let them. Your job is to read every draft and fix anything that is not how you really do it. After two or three rounds, it sounds like you, because the knowledge is yours. The tool never overrules you.

What if the group says no?

Then you have lost nothing but one conversation, and you still have finished samples in hand. You can offer one free document to lower the bar, and you can take the same samples to any other group in town. Denver has many. Your samples work everywhere.

Am I stepping on the HR team's toes?

No, and you say so out loud in the pitch. HR handles hiring, benefits, payroll, and compliance. You handle floor operations, training content, and openings. Different lane. You make their job easier, because trained people on clear systems are easier to manage.

Is twenty dollars a month really all I need to spend?

Yes. Claude Pro is your only required cost. No office, no staff, no software suite. That is the beauty of it.

What if I have a bad health week?

You rest. The work waits. If you are on a retainer, a slow week does not cost you anything, because you are paid for the finished work over the month, not by the hour. This is built for exactly that.

What if they say this is already part of my job?

That is a fair question, and you have good answers, covered in the pitch section. You can agree on a defined extra project with its own scope and a stipend, so the extra work is recognized and paid. Or you can keep it friendly and set up the paid arrangement when you move off salary, while you build your own library now. Either way, you proved the value. If you are still on salary, get a yes in writing first, and use the Simple Agreement and Scope document in the Tools and Examples folder so the line between your job and this work is clear.

Do I tell them I use an AI tool?

You do not lead with it, and you never hide it. If it comes up, the honest line is simple: you use good tools to write fast, but they are paying for 25 years of knowing what works on a floor. Sell the judgment, not the tool. The pitch section has more on this.

How do I know my prices are fair?

Because they sit inside what real consultants charge, and well below what an outside firm would charge this group for the same system. The Research Notes document, marked 6, shows every range and source. You are a bargain and a better fit, because you already know their floors.

Where do I start, right now?

Open the document marked 1, Read Me First, to see what every file is for. Then open document 2, The Vision, to see the whole picture on one screen. Then come back to this Start Here playbook and begin the first 30 days. The very first task is simple. Set up Claude.

You have done harder things than this, Mark, many times, with a lot more on the line. This is the same work you have always been great at, finally on your terms. Take it one document at a time.